

Five Cs for the future

When you try and take a loan, a bank or a lender looks at five Cs for you – Character, Capacity, Collateral, Capital and Conditions. Character is your reputation – do you have a history of bad credit? Capacity is your ability to repay – a big enough salary, existing debts, etc. Collateral is what you're putting up to minimise the risk to the lender – property for example. Capital is similar, in the sense it refers to how much you have, and are risking from your own pocket. Finally, Conditions define the loan amount and the interest rate, based on your age – how close or far away from retirement you are...

No, I'm not going to give you a finance lesson this month, especially since I consider myself to be pretty terrible on the subject. The only reason I bring it up is because I've modified these five Cs of finance into my own little rules of what will govern the ultimate form factor of the future. I believe it's the convergence of these "five Cs of technology" that will drive the ultimate devices of tomorrow...

The first one is pretty straightforward – Computing. The entire reason that technology exists is that we've relied on shortcuts or machines to do complex mathematics. At first it may have just been to count, but later it was aimed at complex calculations – distance, speed, time, navigation, etc. Today, tasks are broken into calculable chunks and Computed by a CPU to give you answers – everything from currency exchange rates to rendering a game. Put simply, it's the need for as much Computing muscle as possible.

Capture is my way of saying "saving stuff". Everything from your movie collection to your photos, music, the wall paper on your phone, bookmarks in your browser, and just any chunk of data is you Capturing something, and saving it for later. A Google search is you accessing what Google Captured, your Facebook page is a Capture of your online social life. This is one of the most important tasks we need technology to do for us today.

Personally, I think Consumption is main reason the internet exploded at first, not the fourth C (Communication). We didn't want to connect the world to chat about the weather, we were hungry for knowledge, we wanted to Consume. Whether it's reading a web page, a Facebook update, watching a video, listening to

music, you're Consuming content. This is what devices today are best at achieving – your PC and your phone are equally capable of satiating this need of yours.

Communication is what is responsible for Facebook, cell phones, emailing, IM-ing, video conferencing, etc., Regardless of whether we communicate using PCs, phones or tablets, all form factors of devices of today seem to excel at Communication.

Creation is the real chink in technology armour, and has always been. There's always some device that's better at creating certain types of content than another. Your phone can click a photo like a dedicated camera can, make a call as clear as a landline, video chat like on your PC, consume just about any kind of content as on any other device, but it sucks at creation in many ways. It also can't capture as much as, say a PC can. PCs on the other hand are not portable and thus communication is impossible when moving, you cannot capture memories as they happen.

There are tough challenges ahead – for example text Communication and a lot of Creation still depends on the keyboard, while Consumption does fine without one. When it comes to Computing and Capture, your phone pales in comparison to the average PC, and a tablet finds the middle ground for Capture, but fails quite often on Creation.

Each C is also best married to certain hardware and form factors – Consumption is best done on large screens, but Communication is best on portable devices (small screens). Good Computing capability is desired in any device, as is the ability and flexibility to Create, but then portability (Communication and Consumption on the go) suffers because of shorter battery life.

The form factor and devices that will win out in the end are going to be devices that give us the ability to experience the five Cs in the best way possible. Our cover story this month attempts to find just what permutation or combination of form factors, GUIs and the five Cs is most promising. 



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